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WORLD CUP 1996

Our preparations for the World Cup began with a training camp in Bangalore in January 1996. For some reason, it had been decided by the management that it would be a good idea for the team to run from the hotel to the Chinnaswamy Stadium every morning, with the team bus and security cars trailing behind. I still don't understand the logic behind this bright idea or why somebody came up with it in the first place. None of us were used to road running and injuries were bound to happen. I ended up with a sore shin on the very first day, while a number of other guys had problems with their backs and hamstrings.

A joke started doing the rounds in the dressing room about whether we would be fielding on the road or on the cricket field. We were all prepared to run as much as they liked on grass, but there was no point risking injuries by running on hard roads just weeks before the World Cup. A few players suggested calculating the distance between the hotel and the ground and running the same distance inside the stadium instead. The management listened to what we had to say and road running was quickly abandoned. Our World Cup preparations started in earnest the following morning.

During the camp we would get to the ground by 7 a.m. and stay there till 2 p.m. The sessions were long and draining and I made sure to have a big breakfast to keep up my energy levels. I was only twenty-three in 1996 and could digest everything I ate. Every morning I would have four fried eggs sunny side up, with ketchup and tabasco sauce, making two sandwiches of the four eggs, which I just loved. The breakfast would keep me going for hours and I thoroughly enjoyed the long training